China and India in the shadow of the Cold War

In the first couple of decades after the founding of the People's Republic in 1949, China's foreign policy was driven by two overarching goals: consolidating its borders and defending the revolution.[25] An important component was "reassertion of Chinese control over areas historically within the empire."[26] Shaped by these two priorities, Beijing decided to "lean to the one side," with Mao Zedong travelling to Moscow in December 1949 to negotiate a friendship treaty with the Soviet Union in an effort to defend the revolution and as a balance against the United States. Also in the same month, Mao ordered preparations for a large-scale military operation into Tibetan areas.[27] People's Liberation Army (PLA) troops had already marched into Xinjiang earlier in the fall of 1949.[28] Moreover, taking control of Taiwan was at the top of Mao's agenda in 1950, but fighting the United States in the Korean War put an end to that plan.[29]

China and India established diplomatic relations in 1950, but the sense of post-colonial brotherhood that characterised their relationship in the early 1950s proved to be ephemeral and was replaced by rivalry with overlapping interests in their border regions. In 1956–57, without consulting India, China constructed a strategic highway linking Xinjiang and Tibet across the Aksai Chin plateau, a region claimed by India.[30] The increased presence of Chinese troops in Tibet towards the end of the 1950s, and in Xinjiang, represented an entirely new situation in the region. Not since the Qing Emperor's conquests of Central Eurasia in the 17th and 18th centuries, and China's march on Kathmandu in the 1790s in order to punish Nepali officials for challenging Chinese authority in Tibet, had China demonstrated a similar footing